



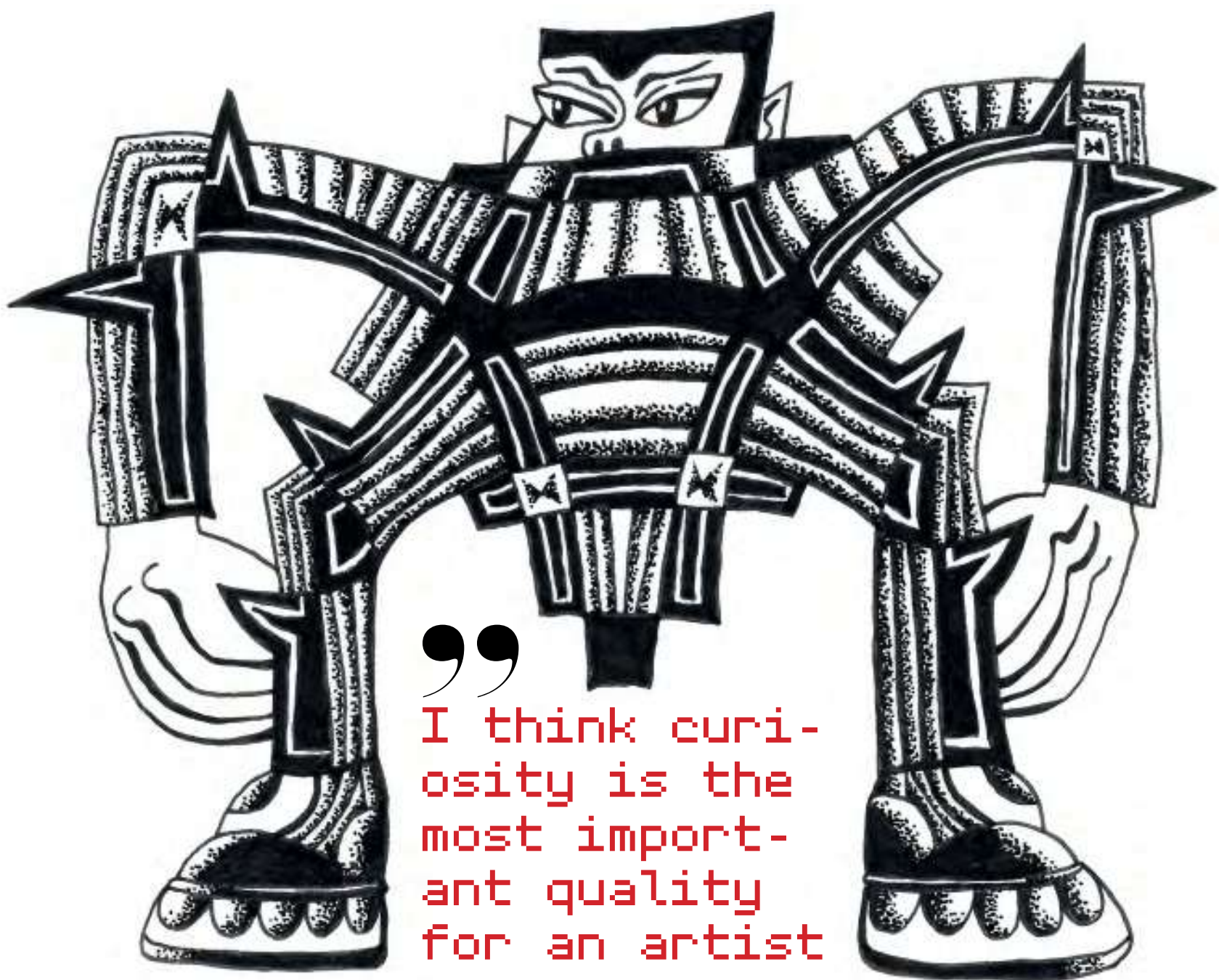
The architecture of imagination

INTERVIEW FATIMA ABBASOVA ILLUSTRATIONS SAMIR SALAHOV

We sat down with artist Samir Salahov, one of the most distinctive voices in Azerbaijan's contemporary art scene.

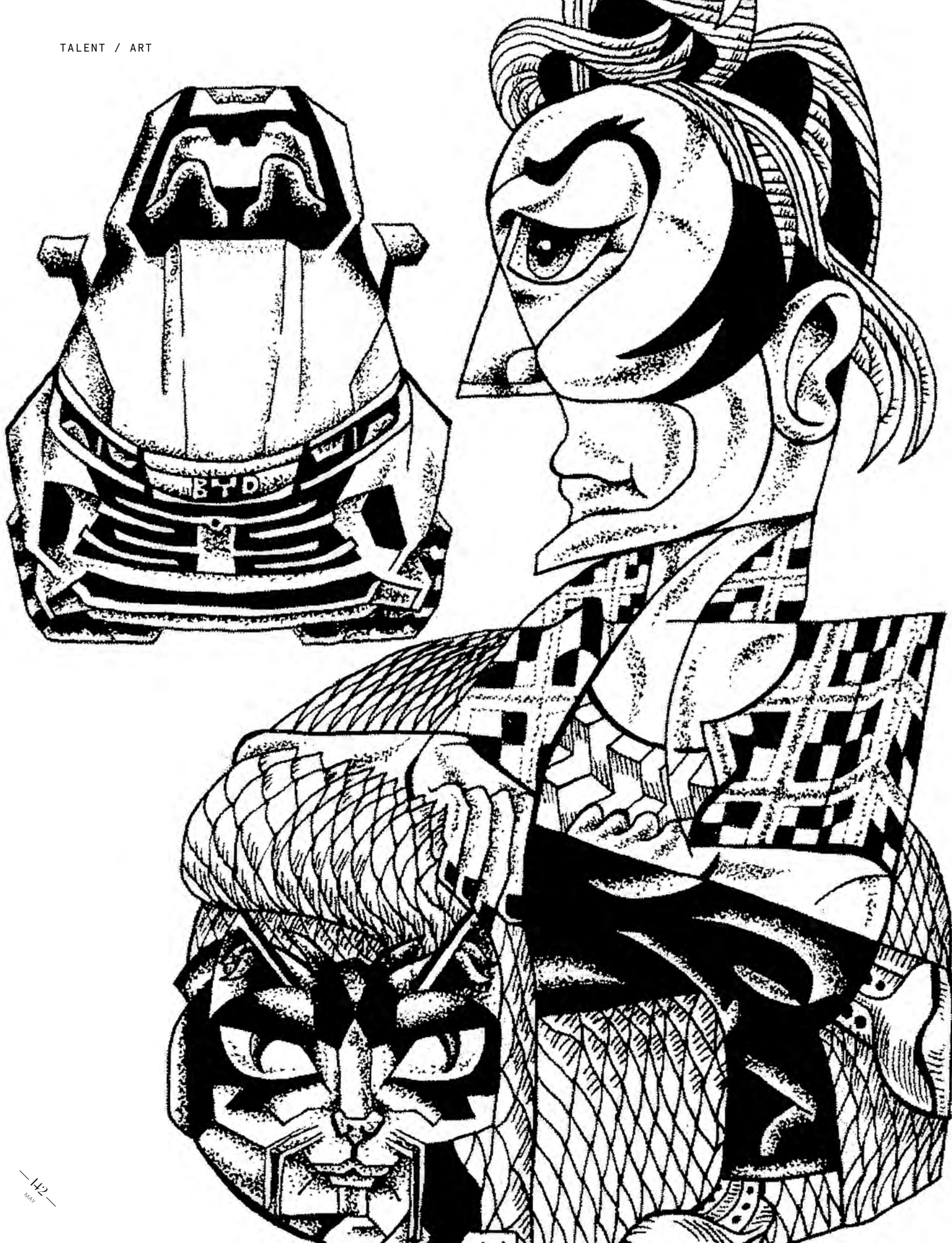
Originally trained as an architect, Samir brings together street art, a strong design sensibility, and a curiosity for new technologies. Today, he is developing futuristic animated 3D versions of his characters..

In our conversation, he reflects on his shift from architecture to art, the gradual search for his own visual language, his complicated relationship with street art, and the doubts that inevitably come with time - doubts that, ultimately, never outweigh the instinct to keep exploring and creating.



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I think curiosity is the most important quality for an artist



Who would you be if you weren't an artist?

Most likely, an architect, as I studied architecture. However, at some point, the profession became less appealing to me. To be honest, it is hard for me to imagine myself in any other role or doing anything other than art.

What didn't you like about architecture that made you leave the field and move into art? People often assume it is a creative field.

In reality, that's far from the truth – it is a highly technical field. I can't say that I disliked everything about it; it is an important discipline that has greatly influenced me as an artist and shaped my approach to work. I still plan everything the way an architect does. However, the lack of creative freedom ultimately influenced my decision.

You create a lot of animations, installations, and illustrations, employing a range of techniques. What do you enjoy creating most?

I feel that my entire creative process revolves around portraiture. I have always depicted some kind of figure – whether human or animal – and I continue to work within this format. I initially started with classical art forms, such as drawing and painting. Today, I am moving towards 3D graphics, animation, and character creation. People, I believe, are at the centre of my interest – they connect all the works I create.

You have a very recognisable style – one that sets you apart from other artists. When looking at your illustrations, it is immediately clear that they belong to Samir Salahov. How did you develop this style?

Thank you. I didn't develop it at any one particular moment; rather, it has been a continuous process. My style evolves gradually under the influence of the artists I admire. There are several artists who inspire me at the moment, though that may change completely in the future. I believe my style has been shaped largely by the people I consider my idols today – Saul Steinberg, David Rappeneau, Robert Crumb, and Ebecho Muslimova. I think many artists recognise this about themselves, though not everyone acknowledges it.

When you like something, you naturally want to understand how

it was made, and through that process of analysis, you learn something new. The same applies to me. Looking at my older works, I can see how much I have progressed, and I like them far less now than I did before. That is why I see this process as ongoing.

In the past, you were engaged in street art. Now, you no longer create it. What was street art for you back then, and what meaning did it carry for you?

I don't remember exactly how I came to it, but it was one of those formats I had always been interested in trying. Perhaps I was drawn to the scale – the opportunity to work on a much larger surface. The act of working in a public, open space also appealed to me, as it directly affects the way you work – your speed, among other things.

Yes, I have stepped away from street art and haven't been involved in it for some time now. It happened organically, as I was moving towards animation and computer graphics. It was quite challenging to fully engage with street art in Azerbaijan, as there weren't many spaces available for it. Street art is often illegal around the world, and there are always risks involved in its creation. At some point, I grew tired of taking those risks.

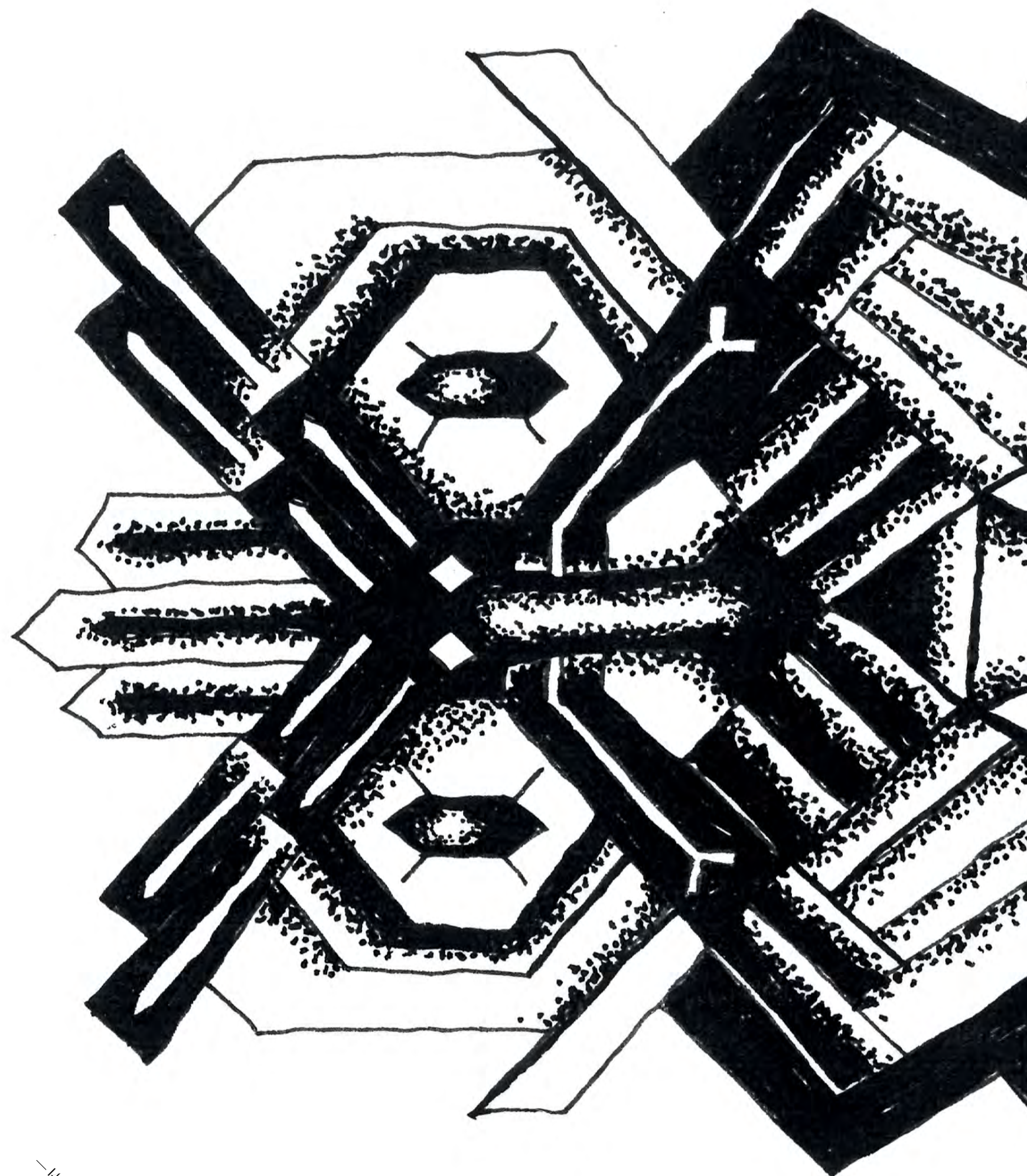
The last time our magazine spoke with you was in 2017. It has been nine years. What has changed since then?

Over the past nine years, I have probably become more sceptical about certain things – more cynical, perhaps. I can see that I have grown artistically compared to my earlier self; I was a different person back then. Now, I am a completely different artist from the one I used to be. In the past, I tended to think less before embarking on something new. Today, I have far more doubts, which significantly slow down the process. Most likely, that is a negative development.

What advice would you give to young artists?

I think curiosity is the most important quality for an artist. — ■

a visual artist based between New York and Mexico, best known for her comic-absurdist alter ego Fatebe, who features in her drawings, paintings, and works on paper





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